

Economics 281: CSP Discussions Addendum

Fall 2026

TA: Josh Aarons (jaarons@ucsd.edu)

Office Hours: 2-3 PM Wednesday, 10-11 AM Thursday; Malk 463 or Zoom ([link](#))

Sessions: 4-5 PM Tuesdays in Eckart 127

Week	Date	Location	Section Type
Week 1	10/2	MCTF 210	Introduction and discussion: Benefit-cost analysis
Week 2	10/9	MCTF 210	Presentations and discussion: Externalities and pollution
Week 3	10/13	TBD	Review for midterm 1 (optional)
Week 4	10/23	MCTF 210	Presentations and discussion: Environmental justice
Week 5	10/30	MCTF 210	Presentations and discussion: Renewable resources
Week 6	11/6	MCTF 210	Presentations and discussion: Taxes and emissions markets
Week 7	11/10	TBD	Review for midterm 2 (optional)
Week 8	11/20	MCTF 210	Presentations and discussion: Natural disasters
Week 9	11/27	MCTF 210	Meetings about final paper outlines (optional)
Week 10	12/4	MCTF 210	Presentations and discussion: Social cost of carbon

Readings and Presentations

Participation in the discussion sessions focused on readings will count for 15% of your grade. One of your responsibilities will be to present a paper with one of your peers. Each pair of students will present an assigned reading to the rest of the class during a discussion section, with one or two pairs per discussion.

As a general guideline, you should address (most of) the following during the presentation:

- 1) What are the key research questions?
- 2) Describe the setting the authors investigate.
- 3) If relevant: What method(s) do the authors use to answer their research question(s)?
- 4) What are the authors' conclusions?
- 5) What critiques do you have of the paper?
- 6) How is the paper connected to the material discussed in lecture?
- 7) What are your key takeaways from the paper itself and how it affects your understanding of class material?

You don't have to present these in the above order and each paper may call for a different presentation method. The presentation should run for around 12-15 minutes. Please send a copy of your slides to Josh (jaarons@ucsd.edu) by the morning of your presentation or post it into the .

Students should sign up to present a paper on the google spreadsheet at [this link](#). Please pick one of the two papers for the theme to present. If another group is already presenting a paper, please do not sign up for the other paper. The papers with asterisks (*) in the "Additional (Non-Required) Readings" section can also be presented. If you would like to present one of these, please email me at least a week before presenting so we can let everyone know which papers to read. Please sign up before the end of week 1.

All readings are available from the [class google drive folder](#).

A note on final papers

The final paper for this class has very flexible requirements so that it can allow you each to pursue a topic that interests you. I would encourage you to think about topics you would want to spend time researching. If you're unsure about how to connect that topic to class, please get in touch and we'll figure out a path forward. I will also be available for one-on-one meetings before the proposals and once you start your research and writing (after the second midterm), so please don't hesitate to reach out.

Readings:

Week 1: Benefit-Cost Analysis and Causality

Arrow, K.J., Maureen L. Cropper, George C. Eads, Robert W. Hahn, Lester B. Lave, Roger G. Noll, Paul R. Portney, Milton Russell, Richard Schmalensee, V. Kerry Smith, and Robert N. Stavins (1996). "Is there a role for benefit-cost analysis in environmental, health, and safety regulation?" *Science*. 272: 221 - 222.

[Mission Bay Wetlands Restoration Benefit Valuation](#): Read the preface and then read some of the "Valuation Methodology" sections for different benefits.

Eyal G. Frank. 2024. "The economic impacts of ecosystem disruptions: Costs from substituting biological pest control." *Science* 385.

Optional: [NPR \(podcast\): How animal scavengers affect human health](#)

Week 2: Externalities and Pollution

Carson, Richard T. 2012. "Contingent valuation: a practical alternative when prices aren't available." *The Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 26(4): 27-42.

Aguilar-Gomez, Sandra, Holt Dwyer, Joshua Graff Zivin, and Matthew Neidell. 2022. "This is Air: The "Nonhealth" Effects of Air Pollution." *Annual Review of Resource Economics*. 4:403–25.

Optional: *New York Times*: [How pollution can hurt the health of the economy](#)

Week 4: Environmental Justice

Tanaka, Shinsuke, Kensuke Teshima, and Eric Verhoogen. 2022. "North-South Displacement Effects of Environmental Regulation: The Case of Battery Recycling." *American Economic Review: Insights*, 4 (3): 271-88.

Banzhaf, Spencer, Lala Ma, and Christopher Timmins. 2019. "Environmental Justice: The Economics of Race, Place, and Pollution." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 33 (1): 185–208.

Week 5: Renewable Resources

G.R. McDermott, K.C. Meng, G.G. McDonald, & C.J. Costello. 2019. "The blue paradox: Preemptive overfishing in marine reserves." *Proc. Natl. Acad. Sci.* 116 (12) 5319-5325, <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1802862115>.

Birkenbach, A. M., M. D. Smith, and S. Stefanski. 2019. "Taking Stock of Catch Shares: Lessons from the Past and Directions for the Future." *Review of Environmental Economics and Policy* 13 (1): 130–39.

Required listening: [Planet Money: The Less Deadly Catch](#)

Week 6: Design and Performance of Taxes and Emissions Markets

Funke F, Mattauch L, van den Bijgaart I, Godfray HCJ, Hepburn C, Klenert D, Springmann M, Treich N. 2022. "Toward optimal meat pricing: Is it time to tax meat consumption?" *Rev Environ Econ Policy* 16(2):219–240.

Goulder, Lawrence H. 2013. "Markets for Pollution Allowances: What Are the (New) Lessons?" *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 27 (1): 87–102.

Also required: [Driving Taxes for the 21st Century](#)

Week 8: Natural Disasters

Kocornik-Mina, Adriana, Thomas K. J. McDermott, Guy Michaels, and Ferdinand Rauch. 2020. “Flooded Cities.” *American Economic Journal: Applied Economic* 12(2): 35–66.

Baylis, Patrick, Judson Boomhower, Jonathan M. Colmer, and John L. Voorheis. 2026. “The Distribution and Consequences of Natural Disasters: Evidence from U.S. Wildfire Victims.” NBER Working Paper Series.

Week 10: Social Cost of Carbon

Carleton, Tamma, and Michael Greenstone. 2022. “A Guide to Updating the US Government’s Social Cost of Carbon.” *Review of Environmental Economics and Policy* 16 (2): 196–218.

Also required:

Noah Kaufman blog post: [The Social Cost of Carbon Is Gone — and That May Be Good News for Future US Climate Policy](#).

New York Times: [E.P.A. Erases Limits on Climate Pollution From Power Plants](#)